

one time to enable immediate gratification binge watching, it is clear that audience expectations and demands are changing the traditional television business model, as well as the types of content that are created. Twenty years ago, *Oz* was considered groundbreaking if not gratuitously graphic with its levels of sex and violence. Now, *Orange Is the New Black* is considered cutting edge not for its nudity or violence but for its mass popularity on a nontraditional viewing platform, its female and minority-driven story lines, and the unique way current social issues are boldly addressed.

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See also: [Oz](#)

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Prison TV Shows, Unscripted Reality

There are a number of reality shows set in a prison environment. For example, National Geographic has produced three: *Lockdown*, *Hard Time*, and *Locked Up Abroad*. A&E has filmed nine seasons of *Beyond Scared Straight* and has a new series titled *60 Days In*. Other reality prison series include Discovery Channel's *Behind Bars*, MSNBC's *Lockup*, and Spike TV's *Jail*.

Lockdown consists of two seasons that cover a variety of maximum security prisons across the United States. Prison gangs feature heavily in the series, as do correctional officers and the various maximum security technologies available. *Hard Time* explores the world of the inmate, taking an in-depth look at parenthood, relationships, mental health, and gang activity, whereas *Locked Up Abroad* consists of interviews with people who have been captured and incarcerated abroad with dramatized reenactments. *Behind Bars* is similar to *Lockdown* in its unrestricted access to maximum security prisons and thematic materials, as is MSNBC's *Lockup* franchise that has 25 seasons of various *Lockup*-related programming, that is, *Lockup: Raw*, *Lockup: World Tour*, *Lockup: Extended Stay*, *Lockup: Special Investigation*, and *Life after Lockup*. Spike TV's *Jail* follows suspected criminals from booking to incarceration in jail. The major difference with *Jail* that separates it from other prison reality TV shows is that it focuses on a county detention center that holds inmates who are arrested but have not been processed through the court system, not a maximum security prison where inmates have been convicted of their crimes and sentenced for more than a year.

Two other series that depart from the traditional prison documentary are *Beyond Scared Straight* and *60 Days In*, both of which appear on A&E. *Beyond Scared Straight* is based on the 1978 film *Scared Straight!* by Arnold Shapiro, and it chronicles juvenile delinquents and their journey through Scared Straight programs run by inmates at correctional facilities across the country that seeks to avert delinquent behavior of children ages 10 to 17 before it lands them in prison. With nine seasons, A&E has found a successful and unique approach to documentary-style prison TV shows. A&E's new reality prison show *60 Days In* places undercover volunteers into the Clark County Jail. In order to keep the purpose of the show secret, releases to appear on screen were obtained from inmates, but they were not informed of the purpose of the show (Gross, 2016). This brings up ethical concerns of fair treatment over fully informing onscreen participants of the nature of the content in which they will be depicted and with concern for not causing psychological harm, as well as the ethics of the monetary incentive for the jail to participate in the show.

Given the number and variety of reality TV shows that document inmates and potential inmates such as those juveniles who appear on *Beyond Scared Straight*, it is clear that the prison environment provides reality TV producers a contained and well-defined “world” that is necessary for successful television programming, as well as the high-stakes drama that TV audiences have come to expect from both scripted and reality TV programming. The apparent “success” of this wide array of reality prison programming does raise concerns about the ethical treatment of inmates and juveniles appearing on such programs, particularly because inmates and juveniles are both legally protected classes of people that are considered vulnerable populations that may not be able to give proper consent to being involved in human research or in this case, appear on-screen. There is also cause for concern due to the high number of inmates that suffer from diagnosable mental illness that may make them unfit to cope with the stresses of a television production.

Documentary-style unscripted reality TV shows set in prisons represent a unique ethical dilemma for filmmakers, unlike traditional fiction-based scripted TV shows. Although members of the entertainment industry are not required to adhere to a code of ethics or research standards such as those imposed on academic human researchers by Institutional Review Boards (IRBs), they must still consider the harm and trauma that may be inflicted on the protected and vulnerable population of inmates by bringing a camera into the prison environment for the purposes of entertainment or info/edutainment. Dr. Richard Levak, who served as a psychologist for contestants on CBS’s *Survivor* and *The Amazing Race*, notes that if reality TV programming had to undergo review by the Human Subjects Committee or an IRB for approval, the majority of reality TV shows would never be made (Levak, 2003). Reality TV scholars Annette Hill and Richard Crew both suggest ethics should be considered by reality TV producers, especially the fair and responsible treatment of nonprofessional actors, and the ethical presentation of participants’ stories and experiences (Crew, 2007; Hill, 2005). Crew goes on to note that “Failing to treat non-professional actors fairly can have serious consequences, especially for psychologically unsuited participants” (Crew, 2007, p. 10). Although these scholars were writing on the ethical concerns of game-style reality TV shows, the same concerns must be addressed by reality producers working in a prison setting with inmate participants, many of whom may have very serious psychological issues that are exacerbated in the prison environment.

Although documentary-style prison reality TV shows provide the general audience with a deeper understanding of American prisons and inmate culture than they would otherwise have, there are ethical issues that must be carefully considered by production companies to make sure they inflict the least harm possible on the participants they film. Although most prison reality shows chronicle inmates who have been convicted of crimes, *60 Days In* exposes noncriminal volunteers to the environment of a county jail and may cause unforeseen harm to the participants. Given the psychological harm caused to participants of Dr. Philip Zimbardo’s famous Stanford Prison Experiment that was conducted in 1971 and led to the creation of ethical guidelines to avoid harmful treatment of participants, reality TV producers would be wise to reconsider the long-term effects on volunteer participants in shows like *60 Days In*. Gaining insider access to prison culture must not come at the expense of harm to others, even if those others are convicted inmates.

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See also: [Prison TV Shows, Scripted](#)

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Prison Work Programs

Since the earliest penitentiaries, the implied link between idleness and delinquent behavior can be seen in the emphasis on work and industriousness. Hard work was seen as antithetical to criminal behavior acting either as a cure, a deterrent, or merely an effective obstacle in returning to a life of crime. Despite the passage of time and the change in correctional policies, this connection remains. In many jurisdictions, those incarcerated may be required to either work or obtain vocational skills that would increase the possibility of employment after release. Prison work has been categorized as operational assignments (aiding the essential functions of the institution), community service work assignments (addressing the greater needs of the local community), correctional industries (creating goods and services that often reduce costs for statewide governmental purchases), and work release programs (allowing the individual to reintegrate back into the labor force). Advocates of prison work highlight potential links to reduced recidivism, increasing hireable skills, and increasing prisoners' employment opportunities upon release. Critics highlight the low wages, workplace safety, and a profit motive that supersedes the work's rehabilitative value.

In the early days of U.S. prisons, prison work was contracted out to private employers who provided the raw materials and necessary machines. The free labor gave incredible advantage to these partnerships over competitors who were paying their workers competitive wages. The combination of corruption, organized labor, and unemployment led to criminal justice policy reform limiting such industry to products that only could be purchased by the state or in labor-intensive maintenance